Plaid's Interview Prep Guide

We're excited to get to know you through our interview process — and we want you to feel prepared and confident every step of the way.

This guide is designed to give you a clear picture of what to expect, how to prepare, and how to set yourself up for success. You'll find details on our interview philosophy, technical setup tips, and what we're looking for in each round.

Our goal isn't perfection — it's to understand how you think, solve problems, and approach real-world challenges. We're looking for people who bring curiosity, creativity, and strong problem-solving skills to the table. So read through, get your environment set up, and come ready to show us how you think.

You got this! 👊

Our Interview Philosophy

At Plaid, we look for people with "spikes"—distinct areas of strength that will accelerate our business and enrich our culture. While we don't expect candidates to be strong in every area, we value notable strengths in some areas, even if that means there are weaknesses in others. During the interview process, one of our goals is to understand where your spikes lie—your strengths, your growth areas—so we can make a thoughtful, well-informed decision.

The Interview Process + Timeline Expectations:

Interview Process:

- Prescreen: Take home Coderpad Assessment
- First Round: 60 Minute Backend Coding Interview
- Recruiter Prep Call
- Second Round: 60 Minute AI Coding Interview
- Final Round: 45 Minute Technical Deep Dive/Behavioral Interview

Timeline Expectations:

As you move through the interview process, please keep in mind the following timing expectations:

- **Interview Rounds:** It may take up to 2 weeks to hear back between interview rounds. While our goal is always to move as quickly as possible, some steps may take additional time depending on team availability and coordination.
- **Offer Decisions:** If you receive an offer, you'll have two weeks to make your decision. We're happy to support you during that time with any questions or conversations with the team that could help.
- **Communication:** We'll keep you updated along the way, but don't hesitate to reach out if you're ever unsure about where things stand or need more clarity on timelines.

Coding Interview Tips

Set yourself up for success:

📌 General Approach

- Our questions are not pure LeetCode-style puzzles, but many do have algorithmic components. **Consider both correctness and efficiency in your solution**.
- Spend a few minutes upfront to **talk through your approach before** you start coding.
- Use your time wisely and **focus on reaching a working solution**—you'll hit multiple milestones along the way.

💻 Technical Setup

- You'll be coding on your own machine and screen sharing during the interview.
- Plaid conducts technical interviews in CoderPad, where you can write, run, and debug code in real time. Before your interview, explore the CoderPad Sandbox or Candidate Interview Prep Guide to get comfortable with the platform.
- If you're using a Mac, be sure to enable screen sharing in advance to avoid technical delays:

    1. Open System Preferences > Security & Privacy > Privacy tab.
    2. Click Screen Recording and check the box for your browser or video conferencing app.
    3. You may need to click the lock and enter your Mac password to make changes.

First Round:

👩‍💻👨‍💻Backend Coding Interview (60 minutes)

In this interview, we will have you code up a solution to a given problem. This problem will have **multiple milestones** so make sure to keep that in mind while working through the exercise, and the **goal is to get to a working solution**. Feel free to **use the programming language you are most comfortable with.**

You'll be evaluated on:

- **Correctness**: did your solution solve the given problem?
- **Efficiency**: does your solution avoid using unnecessary memory and cpu?
- **Organization & Planning**: did you clearly think through the problem, and make a plan that set you up to build a working solution?
- **Code Quality**: is your code written in a clean, logical way that makes it readable for you and other team members in the future?
- **Testing**: did you incorporate tests for both basic and edge cases into your solution to confirm it is working correctly?
- **Communication:** are you able to talk through your thought process and consider feedback?

During the Interview:

- **Use any language you're very comfortable with**—one where you're fluent and productive. If you're strong in multiple languages, consider choosing the most concise one with the least boilerplate (e.g., Python > Java).
- **Think out loud** and ask clarifying questions. Let the interviewer understand how you reason through problems.
- If time runs out, **walk us through what you'd do nex**t: how you'd refactor or improve the code for production-readiness.
- We strongly **recommend using Google Chrome** for your interview to ensure the best experience and minimize potential technical issues.
- ⚠️ **Please disable GitHub Copilot or any AI pair-programming tools during the interview so we can evaluate *your* design and fluency.**

Recruiter Prep Phone Call

A brief conversation with your recruiter to walk through what to expect in the next stages, cover a few logistical and administrative details, and answer any questions you have. This phone call should take no more than 20 mins.

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Second Round:

👩‍💻👨‍💻AI Coding Interview (60 minutes)

This interview evaluates how you design and build systems using AI tools.

You will work through a **multi-part coding problem**, with each stage building on the previous one. You are expected to **use an AI coding tool** (e.g., Claude Code, Codex, Cursor, Copilot) throughout. Ensure that you come to the interview with a completely empty project - no need to come with a pre-built skeleton or prompt. Additionally, please do not use custom skills, rules, MCPs, or agent plug-ins. Formatter, linter, and language IDE extensions are fine.

This interview is designed to reflect real-world development, where effective use of AI tools is essential. You'll be asked to build something 0 → 1.

You'll be Evaluated on:

- How you use AI tools to generate and refine solutions
- How you reason about and validate generated code
- How you incrementally extend a system as requirements evolve

What to Expect:

- Live coding in a progressing through sequential milestones in a single codebase
- Active use of an AI tool throughout the interview
- Screen sharing with clear explanation of your approach

You Should be Prepared to:

- Prompt AI tools effectively
- Evaluate, modify, and debug generated code
- Verify correctness and adapt as requirements evolve
- Communicate your reasoning clearly

During the Interview:

- Ensure you have an AI coding tool of your choice set up and ready to use on your personal computer, which you will use for completing the coding problem for the interview
- Ensure you have a working local development environment
- Ensure you have screen sharing capability; make sure you have permissions set up for sharing in Google Meet

- You will be asked to export and share the AI tool use history with us, along with the code you wrote, at the end of the interview

FYI: Any candidates who complete the AI-Assisted Coding interview will receive a $20 visa gift card through Tremendous within 2 weeks of their interview.

Final Round

💬 Mini All-Around (45 minutes)

A mix of a technical deep dive on a project you've built and a behavioral conversation.

For the technical deep dive, expect a Plaid engineer to focus on:

- The problem you set out to solve and who it was for
- Your technical decisions—the tradeoffs you weighed and why you landed where you did
- How you got unblocked, worked with others, and owned the outcome
- Your alignment with Plaid's values and culture, including why Plaid

💡 **Tips:**

- Come with 1–3 projects in mind. Internship projects typically make stronger examples than classwork.
- Be ready to switch projects if prompted—this isn't a bad sign.
- Pick depth over prestige. We'll ask "why" more than once, so choose work you know inside and out.
- Be specific about what you personally did and decided, not just what the team shipped.
- Think about what you'd redo with more time, and where AI tools helped versus where you had to rework their output.
- Reflect in advance on why you want to join Plaid—we're excited to hear your perspective.
- Discuss your work at the level of problem-solving, tools, and approach, without revealing any private, proprietary, or protected information.

📌 **FYI: What if my project doesn't have real users or customers?**

Plenty of strong projects are research-based, ML-focused, or academic — that's fine. We're not looking for a consumer product with a user base; we're looking for evidence that you understand **why** the work mattered, not just **what** you built. Come prepared to speak to:



- **The problem behind the project.** What was broken, slow, inaccurate, or missing? If you improved a model's performance, what is the model actually used for, and what problem does it solve?
- **Why it was worth doing.** Why did the performance need to improve? What breaks or gets worse if it doesn't?
- **How you measured success.** What metric moved, and by how much?

For **class assignments with fixed requirements**, there's often no real problem you chose to solve, which makes it harder to show your reasoning. If that's the only project you bring, we may ask whether you've worked on anything that solved a real problem or had a tangible impact, and pivot there instead. **Come with a backup project in mind so you're ready.** Being asked to switch isn't a bad signal, it just means we're looking for a project that gives you room to show more.